

Running the ISS

The International Space Station (ISS), which orbits Earth, is powered by sunlight collected by arrays (groups) of solar panels on its wings. The electricity produced runs everything on the station, from computers to the life-support systems. Any surplus electricity is stored in batteries and is used to power the same systems when the ISS is not in direct sunlight.

**One hour
of sunlight falling
on Earth's surface
could power
the planet for
one year.**

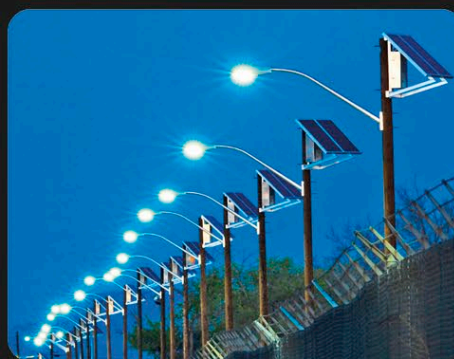
The Japanese experiment laboratory, Kibo, is housed in this drum-shaped module.

The ISS was put together in space by joining different roomlike parts called modules.



Calculator cells

Basic pocket calculators that feature an LCD (liquid crystal display) screen require very little power to function. These calculators are driven by small solar cells mounted on the device, made from silicon.



Streetlights

Many streetlights are now powered by solar panels. During the day, electrical energy is generated and stored in batteries. At night, the energy stored in the batteries powers the lamps, which start automatically.